

Standard Operating Procedure

Medication Order Writing Standards

«Hospital Name» — Supports MOM.5.a through MOM.5.d

SOP No.	[Hospital to define]	Version	1.0
Effective Date	_____	Review Frequency	Annual, or on change
Prepared By	Quality Coordinator Name: _____ Signature: _____		
Approved By	Medical Superintendent Name: _____ Signature: _____		

1. Purpose

This SOP describes how «Hospital Name» writes inpatient medication orders in one uniform location, legibly, and without banned shorthand.

2. Scope

Applies to every inpatient medication order.

3. Responsibility

Order-Writing Clinician: writes every order in the correct location, legibly, and with a fresh order for any modification.

4. Procedure

1. Confirm you are authorised to write orders — MBBS-minimum or a documented statutory/government-order basis — before writing one.
2. Write every order in the single uniform location, with patient name and unique ID, and administer only from that location.
3. Never use shorthand phrases such as 'CST' or 'repeat all' — write out each order in full.
4. To modify an order, write a fresh order — never strike through or overwrite the old one.
5. Write in capital letters if handwriting, use only the approved abbreviation list, and never use an error-prone abbreviation.

Common error-prone abbreviations to avoid include "U" for units (misread as a zero, causing a 10-fold overdose), "QD"/"QOD" (mistaken for each other), a trailing zero as in "1.0 mg" (misread as 10 mg), and "MgSO4"/"MSO4" (confused with each other).
6. Write separate, separately timed orders for different strengths of the same drug — except for vitamin and/or mineral combinations, which may be ordered together.
7. If you receive an incomplete order from another prescriber, do not fill the gap yourself — contact them directly for clarification.

5. Records

Supported by all 5 records in the MOM.5 Required Records pack.

6. Related Documents

- Policy on Uniform Medication Orders (HCO/MOM/POL/05) — MOM.5 policy

7. Review

Reviewed annually, and immediately after any order-transcription error.

8. References

- Institute for Safe Medication Practices (ISMP). (n.d.). List of Error-Prone Abbreviations, Symbols, and Dose Designations. <https://home.ecri.org/blogs/ismmp-resources> — the basis for the hospital's approved abbreviation list and banned error-prone abbreviations.